

Hampton Court Palace - Kids

UK Family Tour

The Palace a King Took for Himself

Here's how to get a palace for free, if you're Henry the Eighth. This gorgeous red-brick palace was built starting in 1515 by Cardinal Wolsey, the king's most powerful minister — so grand that people whispered it was finer than anything the king owned. Bad move. When Wolsey failed to get Henry the divorce he wanted from his first wife, Wolsey fell from power, and Henry simply took Hampton Court for himself in 1529. Henry made it his pleasure palace: tennis courts, bowling alleys, hunting grounds, and feasting halls. He brought five of his six wives here. Remember the wives with this rhyme: divorced, beheaded, died; divorced, beheaded, survived. As you walk in through the gatehouse, look up for the astronomical clock from 1540. It shows the hour, the month, the phases of the moon — and the time of high tide at London Bridge, because guests arrived by royal barge on the Thames and needed to catch the tide home. Notice one odd thing about the clock: the sun goes around the Earth, because when it was built, everyone still believed Earth was the center of the universe. The clock is wrong about the whole cosmos, and it's still beautiful.

Related listening: The same Henry the Eighth of the mound legend took Hampton Court from Cardinal Wolsey. Listen back — “King Henry's Mound and the Secret Keyhole” (Richmond Park, Day 2).

The Six Wives Who Lived Here

You already know the rhyme: divorced, beheaded, died; divorced, beheaded, survived. But some of those wives are not just names here. They lived, married, gave birth, and even died inside these very walls, so as you walk around, imagine them here with you.

Wife number three was Jane Seymour, and hers is the saddest and the most important story. Henry had waited his whole life for a healthy son to be his heir, and in October of 1537, right here at Hampton Court, Jane gave him one, a baby prince named Edward. There were bonfires and church bells across the whole country. And then, just twelve days later, still in this palace, Jane became terribly ill and died. Henry was heartbroken. Out of all six wives, Jane is the only one he chose to be buried next to when his own turn came. She gave him the thing he wanted most, and it cost her everything.

Wife number five was Katherine Howard, only a teenager, and her terrible day in the long gallery you may have heard about already. Wife number six was Catherine Parr, and she has a happier link to this place, because Henry actually married her here at Hampton Court in the summer of 1543, in a small private chapel room. She was clever, kind to Henry's three children, and she was the one who survived him.

Here is a detail to hunt for. Look above one of the gateways for two letters twisted together, an H and an A. They stand for Henry and Anne, meaning Anne Boleyn, wife number two, the one who was beheaded. When she fell from favour, workmen were sent rushing around the palace to chip out every H and A and replace them with H and J for Jane Seymour, because a king did not want reminders of a disgraced wife. But they worked fast, and they missed a few. So somewhere above your head, carved in stone, Anne

Boleyn is still holding hands with Henry, five hundred years later, only because a busy stonemason didn't look up. See if you can be the one who spots her.

Arrive by River, and Look Up

Here's a game to play in your head. Forget the car park and the ticket gate. To arrive at Hampton Court the proper Tudor way, you came by boat. The Thames was the great highway of Henry's England, faster and cleaner than the muddy, robber-filled roads, and important guests glided up to the palace in painted royal barges rowed by teams of oarsmen. That is the real reason the astronomical clock over the gateway shows the time of high tide at London Bridge. It wasn't decoration. If you got the tide wrong, your barge could be stuck for hours, so people genuinely checked that clock the way you'd check a train time.

Now look at the walls as you pass through the courtyards, and hunt for round faces made of terracotta, which is baked orange clay. Those are Roman emperors, made by an Italian artist for Cardinal Wolsey more than five hundred years ago. Wolsey was showing off, saying to every visitor, I am modern, I am rich, I know the newest art from Italy. It was the Tudor equivalent of covering your house in the coolest, most expensive thing money could buy. Look too for Wolsey's own badge on the stonework, and enjoy the fact that the man who built all this bragging never got to enjoy it, because the king took it away from him.

Then, the best look-up of the whole day. Step into the Chapel Royal and lift your eyes to the ceiling. It is a deep, glowing blue, the colour of a night sky, studded and ribbed with gold, with golden angels blowing trumpets hanging down. It was made of wood and painted for Henry nearly five hundred years ago, and unlike most of the palace it has barely changed. Kings and queens knelt under that exact ceiling. And in the Great Hall next door, look up again at the enormous wooden roof, held together with no nails, just gigantic beams of oak jigsawed together by carpenters who never saw a machine. Two ceilings, one blue and gold, one all timber, both hundreds of years old, both still up there waiting for you to notice them.

What Happened to Cardinal Wolsey

So Henry took this beautiful palace from Cardinal Wolsey. But what actually happened to Wolsey himself? His story is a proper rise and fall, and it is worth knowing, because it tells you exactly how dangerous it was to be the king's favourite.

Start with the rise. Wolsey was not born rich or royal. His father was a butcher in a town called Ipswich, an ordinary man who sold meat. And yet clever, hard-working Wolsey climbed all the way up to become a cardinal, a top churchman, and the most powerful person in England after the king. He ran the whole country for Henry. He was so grand that a visitor from Italy said you had to speak to Wolsey almost as though he were the king. Imagine, a butcher's son, building a palace finer than the king's own. For years, it worked beautifully.

Then came the fall, and it came from one problem Wolsey could not solve. Henry desperately wanted to end his first marriage, to Catherine of Aragon, so he could marry Anne Boleyn instead. Only the Pope in Rome could allow it, and Wolsey was told, sort it out, make it happen. But the Pope kept saying no, and no matter how hard Wolsey tried, he simply could not deliver what the king wanted. And a king who does not get what he wants stops being your friend very quickly.

In the year fifteen twenty-nine, Henry stripped Wolsey of his power and his palaces, including this one. Then Wolsey was accused of treason, the most serious crime of all, and ordered to travel to London to face the king's anger, probably to be locked in the Tower and executed. He never got there. On the journey south, old and exhausted and ill, he stopped at an abbey in Leicester, and there he died, in November fifteen thirty. And people remembered his sad last words, that if he had only served God as carefully as he had served the king, God would not have abandoned him now, in his old age. The man who built all this splendour died worn out and disgraced on a road, and his glittering palace simply carried on without him.

The Tudor Kitchens: Feeding 600 People Twice a Day

Follow your nose to the Tudor kitchens — the biggest kitchens of their time in England, fifty-five rooms run by two hundred staff. Their job: feed the six hundred people of Henry's court, twice a day, every day. The court ate its way through unbelievable amounts of food — records show over a thousand oxen and eight thousand sheep in a single year, washed down by hundreds of thousands of liters of ale, because even kids drank weak beer — the water wasn't safe. Stand in front of the great roasting fireplace: it burned about a tonne and a half of wood a day, and turning the spit was a real job for a real boy, called a spit boy, who roasted alongside the meat for hours. On special days, costumed cooks still prepare Tudor food here over the actual fire — if it's lit today, you've hit the jackpot. Look for the pastry ovens where cooks built "coffins" — that's really what they called the thick pastry cases they baked meat inside. The pastry was the container, not the treat. And keep an eye out for the wine fountain in the courtyard, a working replica of one Henry really had. At big parties, it flowed with actual wine.

A Kitchen Boy's Long Day

Imagine you are a boy, maybe your age, working in these kitchens in Henry's time. Your day starts before the sun is up. It is dark, it is freezing outside, but not in here, because the great fires never fully go out. Somebody has to keep them fed all night, and quite often that somebody sleeps right here on the kitchen floor, near the warmth, because there is nowhere else to go.

Your job might be turning the spit, the long metal rod that holds the meat over the fire. You crank it, slowly, for hours, and the heat roars into your face until your cheeks are scarlet and your eyebrows feel like they might singe off. Some kitchens had a little screen to protect the spit boy, and some boys just tied a wet cloth over their face and got on with it. Or maybe you work in the scullery, scrubbing an endless mountain of greasy pots and giant cauldrons in cold water until your hands are raw. There were no rubber gloves, no washing-up liquid, just sand and grease and you.

Now think about the drink. Down below the kitchens are the cellars, cool stone rooms stacked with barrels, and this is where the ale was kept, because remember, almost nobody drank plain water, it wasn't safe. Everyone, from the king to the smallest kitchen boy, got a daily allowance of weak beer, and the palace poured through an amount so huge it is hard to picture, hundreds of thousands of pints every year. There was a whole team whose only job was brewing.

And then, twice a day, the moment it was all for. A trumpet sounds. Servants line up and carry the steaming dishes in a great procession up to the Great Hall, holding them high, walking in careful order by rank. Grand men taste the king's food first, in case of poison. It is a show, a performance, as much as a meal, and you, sweaty and sooty at the bottom of it all, helped make it happen. Nobody up in that hall will ever know your name. But without you, the whole glittering machine simply stops.

Weird and Wonderful Feast Food

You have heard how much food went through these kitchens. But on a really big feast day, the cooks did not just cook a lot, they showed off, and some of the things they made were spectacular, and a little bit bonkers.

Take the peacock. Nobody actually ate peacock because it tasted nice, it was tough and chewy. They ate it because it looked amazing. The cooks would very carefully peel the whole feathery skin off the bird in one piece, roast the meat, and then dress the cooked bird back up in its own feathers so it arrived at the table looking alive, tail fanned out in all its colours. Sometimes they even soaked a scrap of cotton in

something that would burn, tucked it in the peacock's beak, and lit it, so the bird seemed to breathe fire and smoke as the servants carried it in. Imagine that gliding toward you through the candlelight.

Then there were subtleties. That is the Tudor word for sculptures made entirely out of sugar and almond paste, sometimes as big as a model castle, with towers and walls and little figures, and all of it could be eaten. A subtlety might show a castle, or a lion, or a whole scene from a story, and it was carried in between courses purely so that everyone would gasp. Sugar was fantastically expensive back then, so building a palace out of it was a bit like building one out of gold. It said, look how rich the king is, he can eat treasure. There was even a sweet almond paste called marchpane, moulded into fruits and flowers and coats of arms, and often brushed with real gold so it glittered.

And here is a detail that might make you laugh. There is an old nursery rhyme about four and twenty blackbirds baked in a pie, that begin to sing when the pie is opened. That actually came from a real Tudor party trick. Cooks would bake an empty pastry crust, then slip live birds underneath it just before serving, so that when the pie was cut open at the table, the birds all flapped out in a panic. No, you could not eat that pie afterwards. That was never the point. The point, once again, was to make every single guest say wow.

The Screaming Gallery: Britain's Most Haunted Palace

Hampton Court claims to be the most haunted palace in Britain, and the most famous ghost has a truly sad story. Catherine Howard was Henry the Eighth's fifth wife — a teenager, perhaps only nineteen, when she was accused of betraying the king. The story goes that when guards came for her here in 1541, she broke free, ran down the long gallery toward the chapel where Henry was praying, screaming for mercy, and was dragged back. She was executed at the Tower of London — where you were on Monday. Ever since, that corridor has been called the Haunted Gallery, and visitors have reported screams, sudden cold, and some people feeling faint at the exact same spot. Believe it or not — your choice — but walk it and see how it feels. The palace's other star ghost is "Skeletor": in 2003, security cameras caught fire doors bursting open and a tall figure in old-fashioned robes stepping out to close them. The guards checking the tape had no explanation, and the footage went around the world. Was it a ghost? A costumed guide having fun? The palace, very sensibly, has never said. Ask a warder about it — they love this question.

Related listening: Two of Henry's queens link these places: accused at Hampton Court, executed at the Tower. Listen back — "Prisoners, Traitors and a Polar Bear" (Tower of London, Day 3).

Catherine Howard: The Real Girl Behind the Scream

The scream in the Haunted Gallery is a ghost story, and nobody knows if it really happened. But behind it is a real girl, and her true story is sadder than any ghost.

Her name was Catherine Howard, and she became Henry's fifth wife when she was very young, probably about seventeen, while Henry was nearly fifty, unwell, and enormous. Picture that. A teenager married off to a grumpy old king because her powerful family thought it would make them richer and more important. She loved dancing and pretty clothes and she was, by every account, full of life.

The trouble was that Catherine had a past before the king, a boyfriend from her teenage years, and after the wedding she foolishly kept spending time with a young man at court. In Tudor times, for a queen, that was not just embarrassing, it was treason, a crime you could die for. When Henry found out, he was crushed, then furious. Catherine was arrested right here at Hampton Court in November of 1541.

And this is where legend takes over from history. The story goes that she broke away from her guards and ran, screaming, down the long gallery toward the chapel, desperate to reach Henry and beg him face to face for her life. The guards caught her and dragged her back, and Henry never spoke to her again. Whether that dash really happened, we truly cannot say. But the fear behind it was absolutely real.

She was taken to the Tower of London, the same fortress you visited on Monday, and executed early in 1542. She was still only a teenager, or barely out of her teens. There is one detail people always remember, though even this may be part legend. They say that the night before she died, she asked for the wooden block to be brought to her room so she could practise laying her head on it, to be calm and dignified at the end. So when you walk that gallery and feel a chill, maybe it isn't a ghost at all. Maybe it's just your heart, aching for a frightened girl who ran out of time.

The White Lady, Skeletor, and Ghost Science

Catherine Howard gets the headlines, but she is not the only ghost people claim to see here. Meet the White Lady. She is said to glide near the riverside and the old rooms where Jane Seymour, Henry's third wife, gave birth to baby Edward and then died, just twelve days later. People who believe in her say she appears dressed all in pale white, carrying a candle, drifting silently and looking terribly sad. Nobody has

ever caught her on camera. But a woman who died so young, in a palace this old, does make a very good ghost story.

Then there is the palace's most famous modern mystery, nicknamed Skeletor. In 2003, the palace's own security cameras, the boring kind that watch the fire doors, filmed something strange. The heavy doors flew open by themselves. And then a tall figure in old-fashioned flowing robes stepped calmly out and pulled them shut, as if tidying up. The guards who checked the footage the next morning were baffled. Nobody was supposed to be there. The clip zipped around the whole world. Was it a ghost? A staff member in costume playing a trick? A trick of the camera? The palace has always, very cleverly, refused to say. Ask a warder and watch them smile.

But here is the coolest part, the part where you get to be a scientist. Real researchers came to the Haunted Gallery with proper equipment, thermometers and instruments to measure moving air, and they asked hundreds of visitors to mark on a map exactly where they felt something spooky, a cold spot, a shiver, a sense of being watched. And the answers clustered in the same few places. When the scientists checked those places, they found the ceiling had it right, so to speak, because at those exact spots there were hidden old doorways leaking cold draughts of air. Your body feels the sudden cold, your brain remembers the scary story, and together they conjure a ghost. So here is your mission. Walk the gallery once thinking about nothing, and once thinking about Catherine, and notice how differently it feels. That difference is happening inside you. Congratulations. You just did a real experiment.

The Maze: 350 Years of People Getting Lost

Time for the maze — the oldest surviving hedge maze in Britain, planted around 1700 for King William the Third. It's not huge, about a third of a hectare, but its paths add up to nearly eight hundred meters, and it's a "multicursal" maze, which means it has dead ends and wrong turns designed to trick you. People have been getting lost in these exact hedges for more than three hundred years. Here's a strategy that mathematicians say works in this maze: when you enter, put your left hand on the hedge and never let go — follow every turn while touching the left wall, and you will reach the center. It's slower than being lucky, but it never fails here. Race the grown-ups: kids usually win, and nobody knows why. A famous funny book from 1889, *Three Men in a Boat*, has a whole chapter about a man who leads a crowd of strangers hopelessly around this maze until the old keeper has to climb a ladder and shout directions. Afterwards, burn off whatever energy is left in the Magic Garden playground — dragons, towers, and battlements built for climbing — and if the day is hot, the ice cream by the gates has three centuries of royal tradition behind it. Approximately.

The Oldest Grapevine and the King's Weird Tennis

In a special greenhouse in the gardens grows a plant so old and so enormous it has its own gardener who looks after nothing else. It is the Great Vine, a single grapevine planted in the year 1768, which makes it over two hundred and fifty years old. It was planted when a famous gardener nicknamed Capability Brown was in charge here, grown from a tiny cutting, just a snipped-off twig, brought from another garden. That one twig has become the largest grapevine in the entire world.

Think about that. One plant, but its main stem is now as thick around as a big tree trunk, and its longest branch stretches more than thirty-six metres, longer than a swimming pool, all trained under glass. Every autumn it still grows hundreds of kilos of sweet black grapes, and here is the lovely part, the palace actually sells them to visitors in little baskets in September. Queen Victoria used to have its grapes sent to her for the royal table. So this vine has been feeding kings, queens, and ordinary visitors for a quarter of a thousand years, and it is still going. If it is grape season when you visit, you can eat fruit from a plant that is older than almost every country's flag.

Now, somewhere else in the palace, look for a strange indoor court where a game called real tennis is played. Forget everything you know about normal tennis. This is the wild, medieval grandfather of the sport, played inside a room with sloping roofs along the walls, and you are allowed to bounce the ball off those roofs and even into little windows to score. Henry the Eighth adored it and was brilliant at it when he was young and fit. The court you can peek at today was built for a later king, Charles the First, way back in 1625, and here is the amazing thing, people still play on it. It is the oldest tennis court in Britain that is still in use. So a grapevine older than your great-great-great-grandparents, and a tennis court where a king once sprinted, both still working. Hampton Court is very good at refusing to become the past.

Deer, Fountains, and the Secret of the Magic Garden

When you tumble out of the maze, do not rush straight for the exit, because the gardens around you are enormous, and they are full of things worth finding.

First, the deer. Beyond the neat flower gardens stretches a huge wild park called Home Park, and living in it right now, today, is a herd of about three hundred fallow deer. Here is the amazing part. Those deer are the great-great-great, and keep going for a very long time, grandchildren of the deer that Henry the Eighth kept here to hunt five hundred years ago. Henry walled in this whole park specially so he could

gallop after deer whenever he liked. The palace changed, the kings died, but the deer just kept being deer, generation after generation, and they are still here. Look for them out across the grass, especially the males with their branching antlers.

Look too for the Long Water, a long straight canal like an arrow pointing away from the palace toward the horizon, and for the great fountain gardens with their cone-shaped yew trees standing in rows like dark green soldiers. Everything here was designed to look powerful and perfectly tidy, to show that the king could boss even nature around.

And now the best secret of all, saved for the Magic Garden. You already know it has towers and battlements to climb on. But those towers are not just any castle shapes. They are copies of real towers that once stood on this exact spot. Right here, in Henry the Eighth's time, there was a tiltyard, a special arena where knights in armour thundered at each other on horseback with long lances. Around that arena stood five tall towers, where the king and his guests sat to watch and to feast, high up with the best view in the palace. Over the centuries, four of those towers vanished completely. Then, when workers were digging to build your playground back in the year twenty sixteen, archaeologists found the buried floor of one of the lost towers, hidden underground all that time. So the Magic Garden is built right on top of Henry's jousting ground, and its climbing towers are echoes of the real ones, where a king once cheered and knights once crashed. You are playing on a five hundred year old field of games. Climb it like you mean it.

One Palace, Two Worlds

Here's the strangest thing about Hampton Court: it's really two palaces glued together, and you can time-travel between them in a single doorway. The front half is Tudor — twisty red-brick chimneys, Henry the Eighth's Great Hall with its huge wooden roof and tapestries woven with real gold thread. The back half looks like a completely different building: elegant, symmetrical, with rows of tall windows, like Versailles in France. That's because, a hundred and fifty years after Henry, King William the Third and Queen Mary the Second decided the Tudor palace was old-fashioned and embarrassing, and hired Christopher Wren — the St Paul's dome man; he's everywhere on this trip — to knock the whole thing down and build a modern palace. They ran out of money halfway through. Result: Tudor front, baroque back, and the join runs right through the middle. As you cross from one to the other, you're stepping across a hundred and fifty years in one stride. In the Great Hall, look high up into the wooden rafters for tiny carved faces peeking down — they're called eavesdroppers, put there to remind Henry's courtiers that someone was always listening. The walls literally had ears.

Related listening: Wren again: fresh from St Paul's, he rebuilt half of Hampton Court for William and Mary. Listen back — “St Paul's: The Dome That Refused to Burn” (St Dunstan & St Paul's, Day 3).

The Mole and Wren's Half-Built Palace

The elegant back half of the palace, the part that looks like it belongs in France, exists because of one grumpy royal couple. About a hundred and fifty years after Henry, King William the Third and Queen Mary the Second moved in, took one look at the old Tudor palace, and decided it was hopelessly out of fashion. Everyone rich in Europe wanted a palace like the French king's giant Versailles, so William and Mary hired Christopher Wren, the same genius who built the dome of St Paul's, and told him to knock the whole thing down and start again.

Wren got busy demolishing and rebuilding. And then two things stopped him cold. First, they ran out of money. Second, and worse, Queen Mary suddenly died of smallpox in 1694, when she was only thirty-two. William was so grief-stricken that the great rebuilding lost its heart, and it simply halted, leaving the palace as the mixed-up double building you see today, cosy Tudor at the front, grand new palace at the back, with the join running right down the middle like a seam on a jacket.

Now for the strangest death in the whole story. King William was out riding in the park here in 1702 when his horse suddenly stumbled. What did it trip on? A molehill. A little mound of earth pushed up by a mole doing what moles do. The king was thrown, broke his collarbone, fell ill, and died. His enemies were so delighted that they invented a toast, raising their glasses for years to, and I promise this is true, the little gentleman in black velvet, meaning the mole, whose black fur is soft as velvet. A tiny blind creature underground brought down a king. History does not always feel very grand.

One more twist. In 1986, hundreds of years later, a fire broke out in these very apartments, started by a candle left burning by an elderly resident. Part of Wren's roof was destroyed. But an army of staff formed human chains and carried the priceless paintings out to safety through the smoke, and expert restorers spent six years rebuilding it so beautifully you can barely tell. The palace has survived greedy kings, a mole, and fire. It really does not give up.

Golden Treasure and a Prisoner King

Some of the greatest treasures in this palace are not locked in a case. They are hanging on the walls, and most visitors stroll right past them. Look at the huge cloth pictures covering the walls of the Great Hall. Those are tapestries, and they are not paintings, they are woven, thread by thread by thread, on a loom, a job so slow that one set could take years and cost as much as an entire warship. Henry the Eighth owned hundreds of them and treasured them more than almost anything.

Here is the secret to look for. These tapestries were woven not just with wool and silk but with real gold, thin threads of actual silver and gold twisted into the picture, so that in Henry's day, with candles flickering, the whole wall shimmered and glowed as if it were alive. Five hundred years of dust and smoke have dimmed them to soft browns, but on a bright day, tilt your head and you can still catch a tiny metallic wink in the weave. That is genuine gold, still there, still glinting, after five centuries.

The palace has another jewel hidden in a quiet room, a set of nine gigantic paintings called the Triumphs of Caesar, made in Italy over five hundred years ago by a master artist named Mantegna. They show a Roman general parading home in victory, and they are considered some of the most important old paintings in the whole country. A king bought them because he simply had to have the best.

That king was Charles the First, and his own story here turns dark. He loved beautiful things and filled this palace with treasures. But he ended up on the losing side of a war against his own Parliament, and in 1647 he was brought back to Hampton Court, not as a king in charge but as a prisoner, watched day and night. One November evening he slipped away, escaping through the gardens in the dark and riding for the coast. He didn't get far. He was caught, put on trial, and lost his head. So the same palace held Charles as its proud owner and as its captive. Kings built this place, and this place, more than once, undid them.

The Grossest Secrets of the Palace

Every gorgeous palace has a secret it does not put on the postcards, and here is Hampton Court's. Six hundred people lived and worked here, all eating two big meals a day, and every single one of them needed the toilet. So where did they all go?

Henry the Eighth built something for exactly this, and it had a very grand name, the Great House of Easement. That sounds like a fancy sitting room. It was not. It was an enormous shared toilet. Picture a long wooden bench with holes cut in it, side by side, over a deep brick pit, and up to fourteen people sitting there at the same time, doing their business together and chatting away. There was no privacy, there were no separate cubicles, and there was definitely no toilet paper. Instead people used soft cloth, or moss, or even, believe it or not, the soft neck feathers of a goose. Feel free to say yuck. Everybody does.

Now, all of that waste had to go somewhere, and mostly it drained through pipes and pits, and a lot of it ended up in the moat and eventually the river. So the palace could get very smelly, very fast, especially in summer. That is actually one reason the whole court packed up and left every so often. When the king went off travelling, an army of cleaners moved in to scrub the palace from top to bottom, air out the rooms, and, as they charmingly put it, sweeten the house, before the king came back. A royal palace, it turns out, was a bit like a giant, beautiful, hard-to-clean toilet with a king living on top of it. Stick around, because it gets even grosser, and much more surprising, when you find out who had the job of looking after the king's own private toilet.

The Man Who Helped the King on the Toilet

Ready for the strangest job in the whole palace? Henry the Eighth did not use the big shared toilet, obviously. A king had his own private one, a special padded seat called a close stool. It was a wooden box with a hole in the top and a pot underneath, and here is the surprise, it was covered in soft velvet, studded with gold nails, and fitted with the finest cushions, because even going to the toilet, a king had to do it in luxury.

But somebody had to look after all this. Somebody had to carry the close stool from room to room, keep it clean, bring the water and the cloths, and, yes, help the king himself, and then take everything away and empty it. That person had a job title, and I am not making this up. He was called the Groom of the Stool. Stool was an old word for toilet.

Now, you would think that would be the worst, most embarrassing job at court, the one nobody wanted. Wrong. It was one of the most powerful jobs in the entire kingdom. Think about why. The Groom of the Stool was with the king at his most private moments, every single day. Nobody else got that much time alone with him. So the king talked to him, trusted him, told him secrets, and asked his advice. If you wanted the king to hear about something, you might quietly have a word with the Groom of the Stool. He even ended up looking after huge piles of the king's money. Grown men, rich and important lords, were jealous of the fellow who emptied the royal potty.

One of Henry's Grooms of the Stool was a man named Henry Norris, and his story shows just how close, and how dangerous, this job really was. Norris was one of Henry's absolute favourites, trusted with everything. But when the king turned against his second wife, Anne Boleyn, Norris was accused of being far too friendly with her, swept up in the plot, and executed alongside her in the year fifteen thirty-six. So the man who was closest of all to the king, closer even than most of the royal family, lost his head. At Henry's court, being near the king could make you powerful, and being near the king could get you killed. Sometimes, it was both at once.

Fleas, Baths, and Keeping Clean the Tudor Way

Here is a question that surprises people. Did Henry the Eighth take baths? Not really, not the way you do, and not very often. Hardly anybody in Tudor England did. A lot of people genuinely believed that soaking in warm water opened up tiny holes in your skin and let diseases sneak inside, so they were actually a bit scared of bathing. Instead of washing their bodies much, they did something clever. They kept their clothes spotless. Everyone who could afford it wore a layer of clean white linen right next to the skin, a shirt or a smock, and changed it often. The idea was that the fresh linen soaked up the sweat and dirt and, sort of, wiped you clean from the inside out. Clean shirt, grubby body, and you were considered fresh as a daisy.

To smell nice, rich people carried a pomander, a little ball packed with sweet-smelling herbs and spices, and held it up to their nose whenever the world got too whiffy, which, given the toilets you just heard about, was quite a lot of the time.

But here is the twist, because Henry, being Henry, wanted the very best of everything. While most people avoided washing, the king actually had his own private bathroom in one of the palace towers, with water piped right in, water that could be heated over a fire so he could soak whenever he fancied. And that clean water travelled to the palace through lead pipes all the way from springs about three miles away, and for part of the journey it even ran underneath the river. Five hundred years ago, that was jaw-dropping, almost space-age plumbing.

And now the last gross truth. Everybody, king and kitchen boy alike, shared their beds and their clothes with tiny uninvited guests. Fleas and lice hopped and crawled through the grandest palace in England just as happily as anywhere else. There were even servants whose job included picking bugs out of the royal furs and fabrics. So the next time your bedroom feels a bit messy, remember this. You almost certainly do not have your own personal flea-picker, and Henry the Eighth, King of all England, absolutely did.

How a King Had Fun

When Henry the Eighth was young, before he grew old and grumpy and enormous, he was one of the most sporty, energetic kings England ever had, and he built Hampton Court to be a giant playground for a king. Almost everywhere you walk today, Henry was once playing some kind of game.

His absolute favourite was jousting. Picture two knights in shining armour at opposite ends of a long sandy track, each on a galloping warhorse, each holding a lance as long as a lamppost, thundering straight at each other. The goal was to smash your lance against the other knight's shield and knock him clean off his horse, while the crowd roared. It was thrilling, it was showing off, and it was seriously dangerous. Henry did it right here, in an arena called the tiltyard, the very ground your Magic Garden now sits on.

When he was not jousting, Henry loved to hunt. He would ride out into the great park with his dogs and chase the deer, sometimes for a whole day at a time. He hunted birds too, using trained hawks and falcons that flew off his glove and dived on their prey, which is called hawking. He played bowls, rolling balls across the grass. He played that funny indoor tennis you heard about earlier, and he was brilliant at it. And when he wanted to sit still, he gambled, playing cards and dice for money, and he lost enormous amounts, because when you are the king, who is going to stop you?

He also feasted, and danced, and put on shows with music and costumes that went on late into the night. The truth is, young Henry treated being king a bit like being the star of an endless, glittering party, sport all day and celebration all night. It is easy to think of him only as the frightening king with all the wives. But for a while, he was the fittest, fastest, most fun-loving man at court, the one everybody wanted to watch. Keep that younger Henry in your mind, because next you will hear about the single terrible moment that may have turned the golden, sporty king into the scary one that history remembers.

The Crash That Changed a King

Here is one of the great what-if moments in all of history, and it happened because of a game.

By the year fifteen thirty-six, Henry was in his mid forties, still jousting, still trying to prove he was the strong young champion he used to be. On the twenty-fourth of January that year, at another of his palaces, he climbed onto his warhorse in full armour and charged. Something went horribly wrong. His horse, which was also wearing heavy armour, stumbled and crashed down, and the whole enormous weight of the armoured horse landed right on top of the fallen king.

Henry did not move. He lay there, completely still, knocked out cold. For two whole hours, everyone around him believed the King of England was dead. Messengers were probably already working out how to break the terrible news. And then, at last, he woke up.

He survived. But some historians think Henry was never quite the same again, and here is their idea. A bang on the head as bad as that can sometimes injure a person's brain in ways you cannot see from the outside, and it can slowly change how they behave, making them more forgetful, more moody, quicker to fly into a rage. On top of that, the crash badly hurt Henry's leg, and it never properly healed. It left him in pain, and unable to exercise, for the rest of his life. The dashing, athletic young king gradually became a huge, aching, short-tempered old man.

Now, we cannot prove that the accident caused all of that. People change for lots of reasons, and Henry had plenty of other troubles too. But look at what happened next, because the timing is spooky. Within just a few months of that fall, Henry had his second wife, Anne Boleyn, arrested and beheaded, and from then on his reign grew darker and more frightening year by year. So some people wonder, if that one

horse had only kept its footing on that one January day, might the whole story of Henry and his six wives, and even the history of England, have turned out completely differently? A single stumble. Two hours of silence. And maybe, just maybe, a king changed forever.

The Music King, and the Song He Did Not Write

Here is a side of Henry the Eighth you might not expect. The big, fierce king was also a real musician, and a good one. He played several instruments, the lute, which is a bit like a round-backed guitar, the organ, the recorder, and more, and he was very proud of it. He kept a whole crowd of musicians at court, and he collected instruments the way some people collect toys, owning dozens and dozens of them.

Better still, Henry actually wrote his own music. Real songs, written down, that we can still play and sing today. His most famous one is called *Pastime with Good Company*, and it is basically a cheerful tune about how much he loves hanging out with his friends, hunting, singing, and having a good time. It is almost five hundred years old, and it still sounds fun. If you ever hear it played, that is a king's own music reaching your ears across five whole centuries.

Now, you may have heard a beautiful, sad, old English song called *Greensleeves*, and there is a very popular story that Henry wrote it himself for Anne Boleyn, while he was trying to win her heart. It is a lovely story. It is also almost certainly not true, and here is how we can tell. *Greensleeves* is built on a special Italian style of music that had not even arrived in England yet while Henry was alive. And the song only turns up written down for the very first time in the year fifteen eighty, more than thirty years after Henry had died. So unless he wrote a hit song from beyond the grave, in a style that did not exist yet, it was not him. Sorry.

This is a handy thing to remember whenever somebody tells you a great story about the past. Sometimes the best-loved tales are exactly the ones that never happened. A good detective, and a good historian, always ask the very same question you can ask, does this story actually fit the facts? When it comes to Henry and *Greensleeves*, the answer is a polite but firm no. He gave us plenty of real music instead. That is more than enough.

The Treasure Hunt List: Don't Miss These

This palace is huge, and nobody sees all of it, so here is your treasure hunt list, the things worth hunting down before your legs give up. Ready? Inside first. The Great Hall, the biggest room in the palace, where you stand under a wooden roof like an upside-down ship and walls hung with tapestries woven with real gold. The Chapel Royal, one glance up at that blue and gold ceiling is enough, it is the best look-up in England. The Haunted Gallery, walk the whole corridor slowly and see if you feel the famous chill. The Tudor kitchens, follow the smell of woodsmoke, and if the fire is lit with real cooks working, drop everything and watch. Now three rooms most visitors march straight past. The Wolsey Closet, a tiny room that glows like the inside of a golden jewellery box, the last little piece of the cardinal's lost palace. The Council Chamber, an ordinary-looking room where a few men around a table made decisions that changed England forever. And in the chapel's royal balcony, on most days from Wednesday to Saturday, a full-size sparkling copy of Henry the Eighth's actual crown, close enough to count the pearls. Then head for the King's Staircase, where the painted walls and ceiling swirl with gods and heroes, and the King's Guard Chamber just beyond it, where close to three thousand real swords, pistols and muskets are arranged on the walls in giant fans and swirls, weapons turned into wallpaper. If you have any museum energy left, peek at the nine enormous paintings of a Roman victory parade, elephants and trumpets included, painted over five hundred years ago by an artist called Mantegna, and the Cumberland Art Gallery next door. Now outside, where the running is allowed. The Maze, obviously. The Magic Garden, obviously. Fountain Court, a perfect circle of grass and water hidden inside the palace like a secret courtyard, do one full lap around it. The Privy Garden, the king's own private garden, so neat it looks ironed. The little Pond Gardens beside it, which look sweet and flowery today but started life as fish tanks, where fresh fish swam around waiting to become Henry's dinner. The Great Vine in its greenhouse, the biggest grapevine on the planet. And the royal tennis court, where, if you are lucky, people in white will be playing the strangest tennis you have ever seen. That is the list. You will not get every single one, nobody does. But every one you find is a point, so keep score, and argue about the winner on the train home.

The Tiny Golden Room That Survived

Remember how this whole palace once belonged to Cardinal Wolsey, before the king took it? Here is a strange question. If Wolsey built such an amazing palace, where did it all go? The answer is, it mostly vanished. Henry rebuilt it, later kings rebuilt it again, and Wolsey's famous golden rooms, the ones that made visitors gasp five hundred years ago, were pulled apart, painted over, and lost. All except, more or less, one. It is called the Wolsey Closet, and closet back then just meant a small private room, not a cupboard for coats. It is tiny, about the size of a garden shed, and most visitors walk straight past the door without ever knowing it is there. Do not be most visitors. Step inside and look up first, because the ceiling is the treasure, a whole sky of golden squares and circles locked together like a puzzle, decorated with roses and feathers, the badges of the Tudor family. It looks like it must be solid carved gold. Now for the secret, because scientists actually tested it. That gorgeous ceiling is not gold at all underneath. It is made from a paste of fine sawdust and crushed-up brick dust, mixed with glue boiled from animal skins, squished into moulds like cookie dough, stuck up there, and then painted gold. Tudor craftsmen were brilliant fakers, and honestly, isn't that cleverer than real gold? Around the top of the walls runs Wolsey's own motto, written in Latin, which means, the Lord is my helper. And on the walls hang old paintings telling the Easter story. Those paintings hide a mystery too. About sixty years ago, experts cleaning them discovered completely different, even older paintings hiding underneath, pictures that had been painted over about five hundred years ago and forgotten. Imagine being the person who found that. One warning before you go hunting. This little room is a bit of a jigsaw. Bits of it were gathered up and pieced back together long after Wolsey died, so nobody is completely sure it looked exactly like this. But

every piece is genuinely Tudor, and standing in there is the closest anyone alive can get to Wolsey's lost palace. Here is the game. Stand in the middle, turn slowly all the way around, and imagine a thousand rooms decorated like this one. That is roughly what Wolsey built. And when Henry saw it, he wanted it so badly he took the whole thing. One tiny golden room is all that is left to show you why.

The Most Dangerous Room Has No Swords

Quick quiz. Where was the most dangerous place in Tudor England? You might guess a battlefield, or the Tower of London with its axes. But there is a good argument that it was a quiet room here at Hampton Court, with nothing scarier in it than a table and some chairs. It is called the Council Chamber, and this is where the Privy Council met, about a dozen of the king's most trusted advisers, the men who actually ran England day to day. Privy is an old word for private, so this was the king's private, inner team. While the court was here, they met nearly every day, usually around midday, sat down at the table, and worked through the kingdom's problems like the world's most terrifying committee meeting. And what problems. In rooms like this one, they thrashed out England's break with the Pope in Rome and the creation of a whole new church with Henry as its head, a decision so enormous it still shapes England today. They handled the end of Henry's marriage to Anne Boleyn, which finished with her execution. They untangled his marriage to Anne of Cleves. And in the autumn of fifteen forty-one, while the court was living right here, the councillors investigated the secrets of the young queen, Catherine Howard, the one whose scream is said to echo in the Haunted Gallery, gathering statements and evidence while she waited, terrified, in her rooms just a few corridors away. Here is the thing to really get your head around. None of this was done with swords. It was done with words and paper. Somebody read reports out loud. Somebody wrote things down. Somebody prepared a document, and when the king's signature went on it, that piece of paper could close down monasteries, change what the whole country believed, or end a queen's life. Ink could be deadlier than any blade. Look at the walls when you visit. They are hung in blue and gold cloth covered in Tudor roses and in fleur-de-lis, which are lily flowers, the symbol of France, because English kings still cheekily claimed they were the rightful kings of France too. Then look at the table and picture the meeting. A dozen powerful men, every one of them brilliant, every one of them ambitious, and every one of them scared, because if the king turned against you, the next name in the paperwork could be your own. No dragons, no dungeons. Just a table where a signature could change the world. That is real power, and it is quieter than you think.

The Palace Was a Whole Town

Try this. Stand in one of the big courtyards, close your eyes for three seconds, and instead of tourists, fill it with workers. Because this palace was never just a home for a king. It was a whole working town, with hundreds and hundreds of people living their entire lives around one family. You already know about the cooks. But think about everything else a town needs. Somebody had to wash the clothes. The laundresses were some of the only women workers in the whole palace, and washing the king's own shirts was a real official job held by the king's own laundress, a position of serious trust, because you did not let just anybody near the royal underwear. Somebody had to mow, dig and prune, so there were teams of gardeners keeping the orchards, the flower beds and the fish ponds. Somebody had to drive the taxis, and the taxis were boats, rowed by watermen who ferried people and messages up and down the Thames all day, timing everything by the tide. There were porters guarding the gates like security guards, deciding who got in. There were brewers, bakers, candle keepers, mole catchers, rat catchers, and boys whose whole job was running messages from one end of the enormous building to the other. Now, who paid them all? The palace had its own bank and head office, called the Board of Green Cloth, and yes, it was named after an actual table covered in green cloth. At that green table, officials counted everything coming in, the meat, the ale, the firewood, the candles, and everything going out, including everybody's wages. Working here came with a deal called *bouche of court*, which means mouth at court, your daily allowance of food,

drink, candles and firewood. The fancier your job, the better your allowance. A gentleman might get wine and bright beeswax candles. A kitchen boy got weak ale and smoky cheap candles made of animal fat. Even light had a rank. And where did everyone sleep? The important people got proper rooms, and the better your room, the more everyone respected you. The rest squeezed in wherever they could, in attics, in shared beds, or curled up on the warm kitchen floor right where they worked. So here is your mission for the rest of the visit. Every time you walk through a grand empty room, add the missing people back in. A boy with a message. A laundress with a basket. A porter yawning at his gate. The king got the glory, but the town did the work, and today, you are walking down its streets.

The Crown That Was Turned into Coins

Up in the royal balcony of the chapel, you can stand right next to Henry the Eighth's crown, close enough to count the jewels. But wait. If that is Henry's crown, why isn't it locked up with the Crown Jewels in the Tower of London, behind thick glass and guards? Here is the twist. It cannot be, because the real one no longer exists, and the story of how it vanished is one of the wildest in English history. The real crown was a monster of a thing, made of gold weighing about as much as a big bag of sugar, blazing with sapphires, rubies, emeralds and pearls, well over three hundred stones in all. Henry wore it on the grandest days of the year. Every sixth of January, the feast of the three kings who brought gifts to baby Jesus, Henry would put on the crown and process through the palace to this very chapel, carrying gold, frankincense and myrrh, as if he were a fourth king joining the story. Look closely at the crown and you will spot tiny golden statues standing in it, small as toy soldiers. They hide a secret. Originally some of those figures were images of Christ. But after Henry quarrelled with the Pope and made himself head of his own church, he had them swapped for three English kings who were saints, as if to say, in this country, kings answer to nobody. Even his hat was an argument. Then, about a hundred years after Henry died, England had a revolution. The country fought a civil war, Parliament won, King Charles the First had his head cut off, and the winners decided to get rid of kings altogether, including their treasure. In sixteen forty-nine, the order went out. The royal crowns were broken up and melted down, and Henry's magnificent crown went into the furnace. The gold was made into ordinary coins, the jewels were sold off one by one. Think about that. Somebody may have bought bread with a melted piece of the crown of England. The one you are looking at is a copy, but a serious one, made in twenty twelve by the Queen's own crown jeweller, who used old palace lists and paintings to put all three hundred and forty-four stones and pearls back in their right places. And one last treat. A few years ago, a man with a metal detector dug up a tiny golden king in a field, and some experts wonder if it once stood on the real crown, one little survivor of the fire. Nobody knows for sure. Keep an eye on your feet in muddy fields, just in case.

Chocolate for Breakfast, and the Family Who Left

Long after Henry the Eighth, a new royal family moved in, the Georges, who came over from Germany, and they left behind two things worth knowing about, a room full of chocolate and one spectacular family quarrel. First, the chocolate. Hidden near the Georgian rooms is a little kitchen with one job only, making hot chocolate for the king. Chocolate back then was not a bar you unwrap. It was a drink for the super-rich, thick as custard, dark, spicy, sometimes with wine mixed in, and drinking it for breakfast was like announcing, I am fabulously wealthy, good morning. The king had his own personal chocolate maker, a man named Thomas Tosier, and being the royal chocolate man made him quietly famous. Now the best part. This little kitchen was lost. After the kings stopped coming, everyone simply forgot which room it was, for nearly three hundred years. Then a curator studying an old palace list worked out exactly which door to open, and there it all was, the stove, the shelves, the equipment, like a time capsule. It opened to visitors in twenty fourteen, and it is the only royal chocolate kitchen left in the whole country. Go and sniff it out, and if you are lucky, someone will be making chocolate the old way. Second, the quarrel. King George the Second and Queen Caroline lived here in the seventeen thirties, and they could not stand their

own grown-up son, Prince Frederick, and he could not stand them. It sounds like a silly family squabble until you hear what happened one July night in seventeen thirty-seven. Frederick's wife was about to have a baby, here at Hampton Court. By the rules, the king and queen had to be nearby when a royal baby was born, to prove no one swapped in a fake baby. Frederick hated his parents so much that he refused to let that happen. So in the middle of the night, he smuggled his poor wife, already in labour, out of the palace and into a carriage, and they rattled and bounced about twenty-one kilometres to another palace in London, where nothing was ready, and no proper sheets could even be found, so the baby girl was born on a tablecloth. The king and queen woke up here to discover the baby had been born behind their backs, and they were volcanically angry. Just months later Queen Caroline died, and the sad old king basically stopped coming. The royals never really lived at Hampton Court again. The palace froze, like a clock that stopped ticking, and that is exactly why you can explore it today.

The Secret Sewing School in the Palace

Here is a secret almost nobody in today's crowd knows. People still work inside this palace, behind some of these very windows, and one group of them has one of the most unusual jobs in Britain. They are the Royal School of Needlework, a whole school for embroidery, which is the art of sewing pictures and patterns with a needle and thread. The school is over one hundred and fifty years old, and since nineteen eighty-seven its home has been right here, in apartments in the newer, Wren-built half of Hampton Court. While you are out here eating an ice cream, someone in there is bent over a wooden frame, stitching away at something that might end up in a museum, or on television, or on a queen. Because this is not hobby sewing. When Catherine Middleton married Prince William in twenty eleven and became a princess, the lace on her famous wedding dress was worked by the embroiderers of this school, and the job was so secret that most of the stitchers did not even know what the pieces they were sewing were for. The story goes that they had to wash their hands every thirty minutes and keep swapping to fresh needles, so that not one fingerprint or tiny smudge would ever touch that snow-white lace. And when King Charles was crowned in twenty twenty-three, the school led the embroidery of a special golden screen that stood around him during the most sacred, private moment of the whole coronation. They stitched it as a great tree with fifty-six leaves, one leaf for each country in the Commonwealth, the family of nations connected to Britain. Think about how perfectly this fits the palace. Five hundred years ago, in Henry's day, needlework was one of the most precious arts in England. The tapestries in the Great Hall, woven with real gold, were basically the giant version of it, and a single set cost as much as a warship. Kings showed off with thread the way they showed off with castles. And here, in the same building, people are still doing it, stitch by stitch by stitch, training new students so the skill never dies out. You cannot usually go inside, it is a working school, not a museum, so this is a secret to collect rather than a door to open. But as you walk past the East Front, look up at the windows and remember, this is not just a palace full of old things. Somewhere up there, a needle is moving right now, sewing the next piece of history.